

SAINZSATIONAL

Carlos Sainz clinched an impressive win at the Australian Grand Prix, defying challenges including a **health scare and career uncertainty.**

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Just a month before the start of the season, Carlos Sainz was left jobless for next year after Ferrari chose to replace him with Lewis Hamilton from 2025. Then, after outperforming his much-fancied teammate in the season opener in Bahrain to finish third behind the Red Bulls, the Spaniard found himself in a hospital bed in Saudi Arabia for an emergency appendicitis surgery that forced him to miss the second race of the season in Jeddah.

One couldn't have asked for a more challenging start to the year where he is driving for his career. But the 29-year-old produced a sublime drive to win the Australian Grand Prix.

On a day when Max Verstappen retired from the race due to a rare technical failure in his Red Bull Racing machinery, the out-of-work Ferrari driver hogged the limelight.

Despite racing against time to get fit for the weekend, Sainz was on the pace immediately and out-qualified teammate Charles Leclerc, widely considered the best over a single lap, to put his car second on the grid for the race.

As Verstappen hit trouble immediately after the race started, Sainz was ready to pounce on his former teammate and take the lead. From there, the Spaniard controlled the race beautifully and never came under any threat from the pursuing pack. Ferrari celebrated a 1-2, and Leclerc came home second ahead of the McLarens of Lando Norris and Oscar Piastri.

There are legitimate reasons to call Formula One boring, as the sport has been in the era of Verstappen domination since 2022, and there is no doubt it is easy for the Dutchman as he has the best car in the paddock. However, the Australian GP also showed how good a job Verstappen has been doing to have the success he has had.

For the first time since 2022, Verstappen retired from the race due to a technical issue, and his absence showed how much he brings to Red Bull Racing as his teammate Sergio Perez, starting sixth, could only finish fifth and was nearly a minute behind the winner.